



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times
PARENTS SHOW their support for teachers at a news conference organized by Reclaim Our Schools LA.

California could be in path of a ‘super’ El Niño

It may replenish water supplies and trim fire risk — but also bring flooding and erosion.

BY ALEX WIGGLESWORTH

You're going to hear a lot about El Niño this year.

The term refers to warmer-than-average waters along the equatorial Pacific that can influence weather across the globe, raising the odds of searing drought in some regions and torrential rain in others.

Indicators increasingly suggest such an event will develop later in the summer, and it's possible it could be the strongest of the century to affect Southern California.

The prospect has been lighting up meteorology forums and bubbled into the mainstream consciousness this week with the release of an outlook by the European Center for Medium-Range Weather Forecasts indicating that sea surface temperatures could exceed the seasonal average by 2 degrees Celsius.

A subsequent forecast released Thursday by the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration puts the odds of that happening by late fall at 1 in 4.

Some call El Niños that pass this threshold of warming “super” El Niños — relatively rare occurrences that are more likely to generate wide-ranging effects.

“It’s essentially the upper echelon of El Niño events,” said Jonathan O’Brien, meteorologist with the U.S. Forest Service.

El Niño is one phase in a recurring global cycle known as the El Niño-Southern Oscillation, with its counterpart being La Niña. This cycle occurs when changes in tropical wind patterns — or trade winds — allow a massive reservoir of sun-baked

[See El Niño, A7]

Three unions unite in LAUSD strike threat

Unlikely allies plan to bring district to a standstill

BY HOWARD BLUME

The looming strike next Tuesday at Los Angeles public schools unites three unlikely allies that, together, plan to bring the nation's second-largest school system to a standstill and exert formidable pressure to reach a favorable settlement.

The three unions are United Teachers Los Angeles, Local 99 of Service Employees International Union and Associated Administrators of Los Angeles — all with contracts that stalled well short of an

agreement.

Together they represent about 70,000 of the school system's 83,300 employees and they hold nearly all key positions at campuses — principals, teachers, food workers. There is no question that schools would be closed if any two of the three unions walk out, district officials have confirmed.

“This type of alliance is very rare and it greatly enhances the bargaining power of all three unions,” said Dan Schnur, who teaches political communications at UC Berkeley and USC. “The potential downside is that it obligates each

of them to stay out even if their own needs are met, but if they maintain solidarity, they will put the district in a much more difficult position.”

UTLA comprises teachers, counselors, nurses and librarians; Local 99 workers include bus drivers, teacher aides, cafeteria workers, tech support and custodians; AALA members are principals, assistant principals and middle-management supervisors.

These unions, whose members have different priorities and separate contracts, are betting that their

[See Unions, A14]



BEAU SAUNDERS For The Times

HUMBOLDT BAY near Eureka is a proposed locale for the assembly of turbines.

An ambitious plan for wind

BY HAYLEY SMITH

EUREKA, Calif. — Here along the rugged North Coast of California, there's little to suggest that Humboldt Bay, with its eelgrass, oysters and osprey nests, will soon become a launchpad for one of the most ambitious clean energy projects in state history: a hub for floating offshore wind.

The plan is for major private players to erect hun-

dreds of wind turbines in the bay — each rising as high as L.A.'s tallest skyscrapers — then tow them out to the ocean.

Some experts believe the wind project is vital to California's goal of 100% carbon neutrality by 2045 and represents a key climate change solution. The state has a target of 25 gigawatts of offshore wind energy by that year — enough to power about 25 million homes — and nearly all of it would

come from five lease areas in federal waters near Humboldt and Morro bays.

Yet the technology for wind power that floats — as opposed to standard towers permanently attached to the sea floor — is just emerging, and has never been attempted in waters as deep as the Pacific off Northern California.

It will require innovative engineering even as the state contends with objec-

[See Wind, A7]

U.S.-Iran talks are uncertain as strikes continue

Vance will travel to Pakistan. Israel willing to meet with Lebanon but won't halt attacks.

BY JUSTINE MCDANIEL, MICHAEL WILNER AND NABIH BULOS

WASHINGTON — Pivotal negotiations in Pakistan this weekend between the United States and Iran could hinge on developments in Lebanon, where ongoing Israeli strikes Thursday risked derailing a wider regional ceasefire.

Tensions only deepened amid reports of limited Iranian drone attacks across the region, and as Arab states warned that the Strait of Hormuz — a vital global shipping route — had only partially reopened despite President Trump's assurances that Tehran had guaranteed full access.

Tests of the ceasefire have not yet deterred Iranian and American officials from their plans to travel to Pakistan on Saturday for the highest-level talks between the two nations, aimed at a final agreement to end the war, now in its sixth week. But Iranian state media suggested Thursday that Tehran's delegation may not attend if the Israeli campaign continues in Lebanon.

The stakes are high for Iran, which has been pummeled by U.S. attacks, and for Trump, whose pursuit of the war has been domestically unpopular. The plan appeared precarious early Thursday, amid ongoing disagreement over whether the ceasefire included Lebanon.

Iran warned that continued Israeli attacks targeting the militant group Hezbollah in Lebanon could jeopardize the two-day-old truce. Hours later, Israel Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said his government would open direct negotiations with Lebanon — but subsequently declared he would not cease strikes there.

His move to negotiate with the Lebanese came the day after Trump asked Netanyahu to slow operations in Lebanon ahead of the Pakistan talks, a source familiar with the matter told The Times. Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesman, Esmaeil Baghaei, told reporters Thursday that the talks starting would be “contingent” upon hostilities ceasing in Lebanon.

As Israel's posture on Lebanon injected uncertainty into the situation Thursday, the Strait of Hormuz — which Iran agreed to reopen in the ceasefire deal — remained closed, according to Sultan Al Jaber, a government minister in the United Arab Emirates. Traffic through the strait was below 10% of its usual volume Thursday, with only seven ships passing through in a 24-hour period, Reuters reported.

“Iran is doing a very poor job, dishonorable some would say, of allowing Oil to go through the Strait of Hormuz. That is not the agreement we have!” Trump wrote on social media Thursday evening.

Still, the president had projected optimism Thursday about the weekend negotiations in Islamabad — even as the U.S. position ap-

[See Iran, A3]

A GOP governor could bring federal help — or chaos

BY KEVIN RECTOR

If conservative commentator Steve Hilton is elected California's next governor, as President Trump wants, it would mark a “political revolution” for the liberal state, the candidate said.

The state's Democratic-controlled Legislature, “after all their years of lecturing us about democracy,” would be forced to work with him “to enact the changes that Californians just voted for,” and he would be willing to work with them too, the Silicon Valley entrepreneur and former Fox News host said.

If firebrand Riverside County Sheriff Chad Bianco is elected governor, he would take a decidedly different approach, he said.

“You want to know how I'm gonna work with a Democrat Legislature? I'm not. I'm gonna get every single one of them unelected,” Bianco said. “Every single day, I'm gonna stand on the steps of the Capitol, and I'm gonna tell the California voting public about the idiots in Sacramento that are ruining their lives.”

For the first time in years,

the state GOP is riding into its convention this weekend on a wave of optimism about the upcoming gubernatorial race.

According to recent polling, Hilton and Bianco both stand a chance of winning more votes in the June 2 primary than any of the many Democratic candidates, who have spread thin their party's nearly 2-1 advantage in voter rolls. If the GOP candidates do that, they would advance to a head-to-head contest in November's general election, and one would become the state's first Republican governor since Arnold Schwarzenegger.

Much could change to prevent that scenario. More Democrats could drop out. Voters could coalesce around one or two of those left. Hilton, with Trump's endorsement, could consolidate Republican support and push Bianco out of contention.

Still, the prospect of a Republican governing California, a stronghold of the anti-MAGA movement, has captivated political experts and spectators alike.

[See California, A6]

Palm-sized, 8 legs: What's to be afraid of?

BY SUMMER LIN

There is a spider making a home in Southern California that can grow to the size of your palm and soars through the air riding the wind.

Although the Joro spider, an invasive species that has been spotted across the United States, including in California, isn't dangerous, its size and the web it creates

can seem like props from a horror movie.

“They're not medically significant,” said Pat Wooden, the insect identification lab manager at Virginia Tech. “They're great big bugs, but they're not going to bite you and cause terrible damage. They're established really well, so there isn't a whole lot we can do against them. Their spider webs can get up to 10 feet.”

The spider has recently

been found in California, with the first report in October, Wooden said. They don't have any natural predators and have a big web that is able to capture a diverse range of prey, including beetles, wasps and stink bugs. The spiders are also good at distancing themselves from each other so they aren't in competition.

Wooden recommends that people try not to panic and do nothing if they hap-

pen to see one. The spiders benefit humans by acting as natural pest control, eating mosquitoes, biting flies and invasive stink bugs. Their venom isn't dangerous to people or pets and they seldom bite.

The spiders disperse themselves by “ballooning,” in which spiderlings release silk that catches in the wind, letting them travel. This falsely gives people the im-

[See Spiders, A6]

Bass seeks affordable housing funds

L.A. mayor wants to tap \$360 million from “mansion tax” for 1,528 new units and repairs. CALIFORNIA, B1

Cost of operating Diablo Canyon

Report says PG&E is overcharging customers to run state's only nuclear plant. CLIMATE, A8

Weather
Afternoon shower.
L.A. Basin: 73/56. B6

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Amazon's next big sports test

Prime will stream early round live coverage of golf's most prestigious event. BUSINESS, A9

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